Having bounced back from a point of ultimate submission to fate to a state of inevitable fight-back, I continued, ‘I will not leave you. Remember, you too have families.’

Suddenly I found myself threatening my torturers. Was that a flash of fear that crossed one of the faces?

‘But you don’t know who we are, even if you do get out alive,’ said one of them.

I said I would make sketches of each one of them, identify them, and hunt them down one by one.

Then one of them said in a tone of mock politeness, ‘Sir, we are doing our duty. If what you think is the truth and you stay vindicated, you can slap us with your slippers.’

Twenty-two years later, I have kept my slippers for them.

* * *

When did you first meet Mohammed Aslam of Pakistan?’

Now, what was this, I wondered.

‘Who is Mohammed Aslam?’

‘Don’t act. We know you are good at acting.’

‘Honestly, I don’t know any Aslam.’

‘Ok, let me help you.’ The interrogator moved his chair forward, leaned a bit, and cleared his throat, and continued. ‘Mohammed Aslam is a well-known nuclear scientist from Pakistan. He came to India and struck a deal with you for rocket technology in 1985. Now accept it.’

I shook my head.

‘I don’t know any Mohammed Aslam. But I want to know why Pakistan would send a nuclear scientist to get rocket technology. What’s the connection here? If India wants to do espionage on Pakistan, would it send APJ Abdul Kalam or U R Rao for that? Wouldn’t it be safer to send an unknown person? Does your story make sense to yourself?

The two men were by now appearing to be comical. They looked at each other, nodded their heads and continued. ‘You are right. We were only